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The Slip Earns What the Boat No Longer Does

From the desk: The month's defining document was not a results release. It was a proxy statement. MarineMax shareholders were called to a virtual special meeting on 11 November to approve the $53.00-a-share cash sale to Safe Harbor; the merger agreement bars closing before 7 December without the buyer's written consent, and puts a $31,650,000 termination fee on the company's side of the ledger (MarineMax DEFM14A). A week earlier the company reported what is almost certainly its last full fiscal year as a public issuer: fourth-quarter revenue of $520.1 million against $552.2 million, same-store sales down 5.7 per cent, and gross margin up 270 basis points to 37.4 per cent — with no fiscal 2027 guidance and no conference call (MarineMax Form 8-K). The quarter that lost money on boats made money on everything else. That is the sentence that explains the price.

Last month this desk argued that the cycle would be decided on carry rather than allocation. The evidence has moved, and it has moved in a specific direction: **the earning asset is shifting from the hull to the berth, the bay and the parts counter**. Brunswick's Engine Parts and Accessories segment posted its strongest quarter in years and its Boat segment doubled adjusted operating earnings while the company still describes value categories as under pressure (Brunswick Form 8-K). Patrick Industries put $171 million of marine revenue on the board, up 14 per cent against an estimated 8 per cent rise in wholesale powerboat unit shipments, with trailing-twelve-month content per wholesale powerboat unit up 20 per cent to $4,942 (Patrick Industries Form 8-K). More dollars per unit into a channel whose retail run-rate is still negative is the oldest trap in this business. The rest of this issue argues three things: that the Safe Harbor transaction re-prices service and storage capacity for everyone, not just for MarineMax; that the brokerage market is clearing faster at the top and slower in the middle than the headline counts suggest; and that at a 7.00 per cent prime and diesel 73 per cent above last year, the slow unit and the slow listing are now the only two problems worth your week. This issue closed on 5 November 2026; every figure in it is verified to that date, which means it was put to bed before OneWater's fiscal fourth-quarter release, scheduled for 12 November (OneWater investor relations).

FEATURED STORY

MarineMax Leaves the Public Market as a Marina Business

What $53.00 a share is actually buying

The arithmetic of the last reported quarter is worth setting out plainly, because it is the arithmetic the buyer underwrote. Revenue of $520.1 million was down from $552.2 million, with same-store sales off 5.7 per cent. Gross profit nonetheless rose to $194.3 million, or 37.4 per cent of revenue, from 34.7 per cent, which the company attributes to improved boat profitability and a greater contribution from higher-margin businesses. Selling, general and administrative expense ran at 37.7 per cent of revenue on a reported basis — inflated by transaction costs — but adjusted selling, general and administrative expense rose only 1.8 per cent to $181.1 million. Interest expense fell to $13.2 million from $17.3 million. Adjusted EBITDA rose 26 per cent to $21.8 million on falling revenue. Inventories closed the year at $812.8 million, down $54.6 million or 6.3 per cent, following a $39.3 million reduction the year before (MarineMax Form 8-K).

For the full year, revenue was $2.2 billion, same-store sales fell 5.5 per cent, gross margin rose 240 basis points to 34.9 per cent, and adjusted EBITDA was $112.6 million against a reported net loss of $8.2 million. Management's own framing is the useful one: gross margin has gone from 26.1 per cent in fiscal 2019 to 34.9 per cent in fiscal 2026 on the back of the non-boat businesses — more than 65 marina and storage facilities, IGY Marinas, Fraser Yachts Group and Northrop & Johnson in superyacht brokerage and services, Cruisers Yachts and Intrepid in manufacturing, plus finance and insurance. Safe Harbor is not buying a dealer group that owns some marinas. It is buying a marina and superyacht services platform that happens to retain more than 70 dealerships.

The timetable is now mechanical. The record date was 23 September 2026 with 22,086,735 shares outstanding; the special meeting was set for 11 November; closing is expected by the end of calendar 2026 but may not occur before 7 December without the buyer's consent; and MarineMax owes a $31,650,000 termination fee in specified circumstances (MarineMax DEFM14A). Shareholders have no appraisal rights under the Florida Business Corporation Act. For practitioners the relevant date is not the vote. It is the first quarter after close, when an infrastructure owner's return requirements meet a slip-rate card and a service department's labour schedule.

> *Fourth-quarter gross margin of 37.4 per cent came from the dock, the yard and the parts counter, not from the units on the hard. Source: MarineMax Form 8-K, 4 November 2026.*

The annuity side carried the quarter everywhere

This was not a MarineMax peculiarity. Brunswick reported third-quarter net sales of $1,453.9 million, up 6.9 per cent, with adjusted operating margin of 10.1 per cent — 230 basis points better — and adjusted diluted earnings per share of $1.58, up 62.9 per cent. Engine Parts and Accessories delivered what the company calls its strongest quarter in years on sustained participation and favourable late-season weather; the Boat segment grew sales 9 per cent and doubled adjusted operating earnings; and the company estimates Freedom Boat Club now accounts for close to seventy per cent of the North American boat club market. Full-year guidance was raised to approximately $4.65 of adjusted diluted earnings per share on $5.7 billion to $5.8 billion of sales, with free cash flow of $400 million or more (Brunswick Form 8-K). Segment sales for the quarter were $570.5 million in Propulsion, $380.9 million in Engine Parts and Accessories, $197.7 million in Navico Group and $394.4 million in Boat (Brunswick investor relations).

The builders tell the same story from the other side of the invoice. Malibu Boats reported September-quarter net sales of $252.9 million, up 29.9 per cent, and unit volume of 1,299, up 15.1 per cent — but $51.1 million of the sales increase and 139 of the units came from the newly acquired Saxdor segment, while the Malibu ski and wake segment fell 9.1 per cent to $71.5 million on lower wholesale shipments. Gross margin was 15.0 per cent against 14.3 per cent, adjusted EBITDA margin slipped to 5.7 per cent from 6.1 per cent, and management states plainly that it chose to hold wholesale shipments below retail to protect dealer health. December-quarter guidance is $236 million to $248 million of net sales and $13.0 million to $15.0 million of adjusted EBITDA; the board also moved the fiscal year end to 31 December, making July to December a six-month transition period (Malibu Boats Form 8-K).

Set that against Patrick Industries, where marine revenue of $171 million rose 14 per cent while the company estimates wholesale powerboat unit shipments rose 8 per cent, and trailing-twelve-month content per wholesale powerboat unit rose 20 per cent to $4,942 (Patrick Industries Form 8-K). The channel is taking more content per hull at a moment when the National Marine Manufacturers Association's rolling twelve-month new powerboat retail count was 214,292 units, down 7.1 per cent (NMMA). Richer boats, fewer buyers, and a floorplan clock that does not care which of those two facts you prefer.

What changes for the independent next door

Three consequences are worth pricing now. First, capacity. An infrastructure owner that controls more than 65 storage and marina facilities inside MarineMax plus Safe Harbor's own network has an obvious incentive to raise realised revenue per linear foot and per lift cycle rather than to chase unit throughput. If you operate a marina within an hour of a Safe Harbor property, your 2027 rate card is now a competitive-response document, not an inflation exercise. If you are a dealer who relies on third-party slips to deliver boats over 40 feet, your delivery assumption for next spring needs a second supplier behind it.

Second, brokerage. MarineMax owns Fraser Yachts Group and Northrop & Johnson; both pass to the new owner. Northrop & Johnson's own quarterly data shows what that platform is walking into: 472 pre-owned sales of 24 metres and above in the first nine months, down 1.0 per cent, but aggregate value down 4.7 per cent to $5.20 billion; 1,400 new central agency listings, up 5.5 per cent; and 1,949 price reductions, up 7.2 per cent (Northrop & Johnson). Supply is building faster than demand at the top of the market, and the clearing mechanism is price.

Third, the show floor has already told you this. Fort Lauderdale drew 211 superyachts, up 24.1 per cent on 2025, with 174 of them for sale — 16.8 per cent more listings than last year — yet combined asking value fell from $1.8 billion to $1.7 billion and the average asking price dropped 16.8 per cent to $9.9 million. The fleet for sale was smaller on average, 33.46 metres against 35.59 metres, and younger, 10.84 years against 11.95 (YachtBuyer). That is not a market losing value. It is a market whose mix has shifted down a size band, which is precisely the band where inventory is heaviest.

Key takeaway

The transaction worth watching is not the one with the press release. It is the one that happens in your own accounts when the margin on a hull keeps falling and the margin on a berth, a bottom job and a set of electronics keeps rising. MarineMax took gross margin from 26.1 per cent in fiscal 2019 to 34.9 per cent in fiscal 2026 and 37.4 per cent in its final reported quarter, and a Blackstone Infrastructure portfolio company paid roughly $1.5 billion of enterprise value for the result. Do the same sum on a smaller scale this week. Take your trailing twelve months of gross profit and split it three ways: new units, used units, and everything that is tied to a physical asset you control — slips, dry stack, lifts, service bays, fuel, parts. Then take the third number and divide it by the square footage and linear footage it occupies. That is your revenue per foot of controlled waterfront, and it is the number an infrastructure buyer would underwrite if they walked your property tomorrow. If it has not moved in two years while your floorplan carry has gone up 25 basis points and your diesel cost has gone up 73 per cent, you are subsidising the hull business with the yard business and calling it diversification. Raise the rate card or reallocate the space, and decide which before the spring delivery season takes the decision away from you.

ECONOMIC INDICATORS AND RISK

By the numbers

UNITED STATES

- **Brunswick third-quarter net sales** $1,453.9M · +6.9% (Brunswick Corporation Form 8-K)
- **MarineMax fiscal fourth-quarter revenue** $520.1M · −5.8% (MarineMax Form 8-K)
- **MarineMax fourth-quarter gross margin** 37.4% · +270 basis points (MarineMax Form 8-K)
- **MarineMax year-end inventories** $812.8M · −6.3% (MarineMax Form 8-K)
- **Malibu Boats September-quarter net sales** $252.9M · +29.9% (Malibu Boats Form 8-K)
- **Patrick Industries marine revenue** $171M · +14% (Patrick Industries Form 8-K)
- **Content per wholesale powerboat unit, trailing twelve months** $4,942 · +20% (Patrick Industries Form 8-K)
- **US on-highway diesel, week ended 19 October** $6.276/gal · +73% year on year (US Energy Information Administration)
- **Bank prime loan rate** 7.00% · +25 basis points since 16 September (Federal Reserve H.15)

GLOBAL

- **Pre-owned superyacht sales, 24m and above, nine months** 472 · −1.0% (Northrop & Johnson)
- **Pre-owned superyacht sales value, nine months** $5.20bn · −4.7% (Northrop & Johnson)
- **Average days on market, third-quarter superyacht sales** 445 days · from 542 in Q2 (Northrop & Johnson)
- **Superyachts listed for sale at 1 October** 2,197 · 17.2% of the global fleet (Northrop & Johnson)
- **Superyacht charter bookings, nine months** +18.5% · yachts receiving bookings +1.8% (Northrop & Johnson)
- **Fort Lauderdale brokerage fleet asking value** $1.7bn · average asking price −16.8% (YachtBuyer)
- **Ferretti Group nine-month order intake** €664.9M · −13.8% (Trade Only Today)
- **Sanlorenzo order backlog at 30 June** €1,498.9M · first-half order intake +18.3% (Sanlorenzo first-half 2026 results)
- **Metstrade exhibitors, 17–19 November, RAI Amsterdam** More than 1,700 · three days (Metstrade)

UNITED STATES RISKS

The divergence to watch into the first quarter is wholesale dollars against retail units. Patrick Industries put marine revenue up 14 per cent to $171 million against its own estimate of an 8 per cent rise in wholesale powerboat unit shipments, with trailing-twelve-month content per wholesale powerboat unit up 20 per cent to $4,942 (Patrick Industries Form 8-K), while the National Marine Manufacturers Association's rolling twelve-month retail count stood at 214,292 new powerboats, down 7.1 per cent (NMMA) and MarineMax reported same-store sales down 5.7 per cent in the September quarter (MarineMax Form 8-K). Carry is no longer a rounding error: the bank prime loan rate sits at 7.00 per cent and the ten-year Treasury closed 3 November at 4.95 per cent (Federal Reserve H.15), and the Federal Open Market Committee held the target range at 3.75 to 4.00 per cent on 28 October by a 10–2 vote in which both dissenters preferred an increase (Federal Reserve) — the asymmetry now runs against you. Operating cost is worse: on-highway diesel averaged $6.276 a gallon in the week ended 19 October against $3.620 a year earlier, after peaking at $6.529 on 21 September (EIA), which reprices every sea trial, every delivery run and every courtesy fill. Add trade friction at the border — Canadian-built powerboats entering the United States have faced an additional 50 per cent duty since 15 September on four tariff lines, applying even to goods that qualify under the USMCA (YBAA) — and the credit tail from West Marine's Chapter 11 filing and the closure of 59 stores, about 30 per cent of its footprint (Business Observer). The quarter's realistic bad case is not a demand collapse. It is a spring in which richer, slower-turning units sit on a 7.00 per cent floorplan while fuel, freight and insurance all reset higher.

GLOBAL RISKS

Outside the United States the risk is concentrated in order intake and in the supply side of brokerage. Ferretti Group returned to growth in the third quarter — revenue up 13.6 per cent, intake of €323.6 million against €303.6 million — but nine-month order intake of €664.9 million was still down 13.8 per cent, nine-month revenue was flat at €888.6 million, adjusted EBITDA margin slipped to 14.7 per cent from 16 per cent, and management held revenue guidance at €1.2 billion to €1.24 billion while cutting adjusted EBITDA guidance to €174 million to €185 million and naming the Americas, the Middle East and the superyacht business as the three programmes requiring repair (Trade Only Today). Sanlorenzo is the counterexample rather than the refutation, with first-half order intake up 18.3 per cent to €496.4 million and an order backlog of €1,498.9 million at 30 June (Sanlorenzo). On the water, inventory is the pressure point: 2,197 yachts of 24 metres and above were listed for sale at 1 October, 17.2 per cent of the global fleet of 12,775, with 1,400 new central agencies in nine months, up 5.5 per cent, 1,949 price reductions, up 7.2 per cent, a median 386 days on market among yachts taking reductions, and nine-month new-build sales of 216 against 266 a year earlier, with speculative hulls about 51 per cent of reported activity (Northrop & Johnson). Charter looks strong on the surface — bookings up 18.5 per cent and booked days up 17.4 per cent for the nine months — but the number of yachts actually receiving bookings rose only 1.8 per cent, from 1,641 to 1,670, so the growth is concentration, not fleet-wide recovery, and Fort Lauderdale's charter contingent held flat at 60 boats while falling from 35.29 per cent of the attending fleet to 28.44 per cent (YachtBuyer). Route and war risk remains the live variable behind every delivery and yard-period schedule: trade reporting in late August, citing Marsh McLennan via the Financial Times, put war-risk premiums for affected voyages at around 1 per cent of vessel value against no more than 0.4 per cent before the latest incidents, with some underwriters withdrawing from specific transits (Beinsure). We could not verify a more recent primary war-risk figure for this issue and have not estimated one.

THREE ACTION STEPS

What to do this quarter

1

Re-cut your floorplan model against a 7.00 per cent prime that is not going down.

The bank prime loan rate has sat at 7.00 per cent since the September move and the Federal Open Market Committee's 28 October hold carried two dissents in favour of a further increase (Federal Reserve H.15; Federal Reserve). Build the 2027 plan on prime at 7.25 per cent rather than on a cut you have been promised since spring. Then do two specific things. Take your current floorplan balance, split it by model year, and calculate interest cost per unit per month for model-year 2026 and earlier stock — on a $95,000 advance at prime plus 150 basis points that is roughly $673 a month, before curtailment. Second, go back to Patrick's content number: with trailing-twelve-month content per wholesale powerboat unit up 20 per cent to $4,942, the same floor plan now holds more dollars per hull than it did a year ago (Patrick Industries Form 8-K). If your unit count is flat year over year, your exposure is not.

2

Confirm country of build before you take another cross-border deposit.

Since 15 September, Canadian-built powerboats entering the United States have carried an additional 50 per cent duty across HTS 8903.31, 8903.32, 8903.93.20 and 8903.99.21, and it applies even where the boat qualifies under the USMCA, on top of existing steel and aluminium duties. Canada's counter-tariffs took effect on 8 September and exempt US-built recreational boats, personal watercraft and marine engines, but not trailers, anchors and chain, or some marine hardware; Canada's luxury tax on vessels has been repealed (YBAA). Practically: add a build-country field to your listing intake form this week, make it a required field, and add a duty-allocation clause to your purchase and sale template naming the responsible party by name. One pontoon or aluminium fishing boat mis-classified on a $180,000 deal is a $90,000 argument you will have with a customer, not with a government.

3

Put a price on your slow listings this week, not in February.

The top of the market is already doing this and the data shows the payoff. Average days on market for third-quarter superyacht sales fell to 445 from 542 in the second quarter, while yachts that took a price reduction had a median 386 days on market before doing so, and 449 reductions were recorded in the quarter at an average of about $1.5 million (Northrop & Johnson). At Fort Lauderdale the number of superyachts for sale rose 16.8 per cent while average asking price fell 16.8 per cent to $9.9 million (YachtBuyer). Sort every central agency and every used unit by days on market, draw the line at 180 days, and for everything beyond it either take a documented reduction now or resign the listing. A reduction taken in December competes against the Düsseldorf and Miami listing waves; the same reduction taken in March competes against them after another three months of carry.

INDUSTRY PLAYER PROFILE

MasterCraft Boat Holdings (NASDAQ: MCFT)

A wake-boat builder that has become a five-brand portfolio, and the clearest test of whether builder-tier consolidation produces anything beyond scale.

MasterCraft closed its merger with Marine Products Corporation on 15 May 2026, bringing Chaparral and Robalo alongside MasterCraft, Crest and Balise and creating a new Recreation and Sport Fishing segment. The deal added $33.3 million of net sales in the fiscal fourth quarter and carried $20.4 million of acquisition-related expense across the year, alongside a $10.1 million non-cash impairment in the Leisure segment — the business formerly reported as Pontoon. Full-year net sales were $348.9 million, up 22.8 per cent, or up 11.0 per cent excluding the acquisition, with adjusted EBITDA of $45.6 million at a 13.1 per cent margin against 8.6 per cent the prior year, and adjusted net income of $30.2 million, or $1.76 per diluted share. The reported result was a $1.6 million loss from continuing operations (MasterCraft Form 8-K).

The company also moved its fiscal year end from 30 June to 31 December, effective 1 July 2026, and will file a transition report covering July to December 2026. Guidance for that six-month period is net sales of $287 million to $291 million, adjusted EBITDA of $29 million to $32 million, adjusted earnings per share of $0.66 to $0.76 and capital expenditure of about $9 million, with the first transition quarter guided to roughly $147 million of net sales and about $16 million of adjusted EBITDA.

Why it matters now

Two reasons, and neither is the headline revenue. First, MasterCraft is not alone in resetting its calendar: Malibu Boats made the same move to a 31 December year end in its November release (Malibu Boats Form 8-K). When two of the three listed wake and sterndrive builders shift to the calendar year within months of each other, dealer order deadlines, model-year transitions and rebate windows move with them. Check whether your 2027 programme dates still line up with your lender's curtailment schedule, because the builder's reporting calendar is increasingly what sets them.

Second, the segment disclosure is a rare clean read on where the pain sits. The Leisure impairment is a pontoon write-down in a year when the premium end held up and value categories did not — the same split Brunswick described while posting a 9 per cent Boat segment sales increase and a doubling of Boat segment adjusted operating earnings (Brunswick Form 8-K). If you carry pontoon inventory under a premium-brand franchise agreement, you are holding both sides of that split on one floorplan line.

Watch for

The first transition-period quarter, guided to approximately $147 million of net sales and about $16 million of adjusted EBITDA, is the number that tells you whether the Recreation and Sport Fishing segment clears the inventory step-up and amortisation drag it carried on arrival — the segment produced a $6.6 million operating loss on its initial $33.3 million of sales. Watch, too, for whether Chaparral and Robalo dealer agreements are re-papered alongside MasterCraft's, because dual-brand dealers in the sterndrive and centre-console space will find out in the next two quarters whether consolidation means better terms or simply fewer alternatives. And set all of it against the macro frame in this issue: wholesale powerboat unit shipments running ahead of retail (Patrick Industries Form 8-K) with the rolling twelve-month retail count down 7.1 per cent (NMMA). A builder guiding to growth into that is guiding to someone's floorplan.

VOICES FROM THE FIELD

Reader submissions

Next month's issue takes the Safe Harbor close as its starting point and asks what happens to slip rates, service labour and storage pricing in the first full quarter under infrastructure ownership. That is a question best answered by the people writing the rate cards and reading them, which is why we are asking for your numbers rather than your opinions. If you operate a marina, a boatyard or a dry stack, we want to know what you have set for 2027 on a per-foot and per-lift basis and what you set for 2026, and whether your occupancy assumption has changed. If you are a dealer, we want your non-new-boat share of gross profit and your current days-supply by model year. If you are a broker, send us your days-on-market distribution and the share of your central agencies that have taken a reduction this year, so we can put a North American number next to the 386-day median Northrop & Johnson published for reduced superyacht listings (Northrop & Johnson).

We also want two specific things from the lending and underwriting side. First, where floorplan spreads over prime actually sit today for a mid-sized dealer, now that prime has been at 7.00 per cent since September (Federal Reserve H.15) — not the rate card, the executed rate. Second, what hull and liability renewals are doing in the Southeast and in the Mediterranean, and whether war-risk and route exclusions are being written more tightly for owners planning Red Sea or Gulf transits. Aggregated, anonymised, and never attributed to a firm without written permission; we will publish ranges and medians, not names, and we will tell you how many responses sit behind any figure we print. Submissions close two weeks before the January issue. If you disagree with the argument in this issue — particularly the claim that the berth is now the earning asset — send the numbers that say otherwise and we will run them.

— The Helm & Horizon editors

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